

China Payment Setup Guide

Alipay, WeChat Pay, Card & Cash Backup

By ChinaTripBox.com

- [OK] Alipay vs WeChat Pay: which one to use
- [OK] Step-by-step card linking with screenshots
- [OK] Fees, limits, and currency conversion
- [OK] What to do when your card is declined
- [OK] How much cash to bring
- [OK] ATM and currency exchange guide

Alipay vs WeChat Pay: Which Should You Use?

China is a nearly cashless society. You'll need mobile payment for almost everything: street food, metro tickets, hotel deposits, DiDi rides, and even some museum entry fees. The good news: both Alipay and WeChat Pay now accept foreign credit cards.

Quick Comparison

Feature	Alipay	WeChat Pay
English support	Excellent (full English UI)	Good (menu in English)
Card types	Visa, MC, Amex, JCB	Visa, MC primarily
Setup time	5-10 min	10-15 min
3% fee threshold	Above \$200/transaction	Above \$200/transaction
Where accepted	Everywhere (100%)	Everywhere (99%)
Best for	First-time setup, travel	Restaurants, WeChat users

PRO TIP

Most travelers use Alipay as primary and WeChat Pay as backup. This covers 100% of payment scenarios.

Alipay: Step-by-Step Setup

1. Download & Register

Download Alipay from app store. Use your email to register (Chinese phone number not required). Alipay will send a verification code to your email.

2. Verify Identity

Go to 'Me' \-> 'Profile' \-> 'Identity Verification'. Take a clear photo of your passport data page. This takes about 2 minutes. The system may ask for a selfie--make sure good lighting.

3. Link Your Card

Go to 'Me' \-> 'Bank Cards' \-> '+'. Enter your card number, expiry, CVV. For Visa/Mastercard, Alipay charges a 3% fee on transactions over \$200. Under \$200 is fee-free.

4. Test Payment

Find a convenience store (FamilyMart, 7-Eleven, Lawson) or a coffee shop. Try paying with your Alipay QR code. If declined, check: (a) card not yet activated for international use, (b) daily limit reached, (c) bank flagged China transaction.

Common Errors & Fixes

- Card declined: Call your bank to authorize China transactions and set a travel notice.
- Verification failed: Take passport photo in natural light, no glare, all 4 corners visible.
- 3% fee concern: Keep individual payments under \$200. Split large purchases into multiple transactions.
- Can't add card: Try a different card brand. Visa generally works best for initial setup.

WeChat Pay: Step-by-Step Setup

1. Get WeChat First

Download WeChat, register with your phone number. Add a profile photo and set your WeChat ID. Your friend can help verify your account.

2. Activate Wallet

Go to 'Me' \-> 'Services' \-> 'Wallet'. WeChat will prompt you to add a card. Tap '+' and enter your international Visa or Mastercard.

3. Passport Verification

WeChat requires identity verification to accept payments. You'll need to upload a photo of your passport. The verification takes 1-5 minutes.

4. Set Payment Preference

Go to 'Me' \-> 'Services' \-> 'Wallet' \-> 'Payment Settings'. Set your default payment method. You can reorder cards.

PRO TIP

WeChat Pay links to your card indirectly through a mini-program. If the card option doesn't appear, update WeChat to the latest version first.

Cash & Card Backup

How Much Cash to Bring

You'll use mobile payment 95% of the time. Cash is needed for: small street vendors, some taxis (especially in smaller cities), and as backup if your phone dies. Bring CNY500-CNY1000 (\$70-\$140) in cash. Exchange at airport counters or use ATM.

ATMs That Work

Bank of China, ICBC, China Merchants Bank ATMs reliably accept foreign cards. Look for ATMs in the airport, major metro stations, and shopping malls. The ATM will dispense RMB. Your bank may charge a foreign transaction fee (typically 1-3%).